

THE PROOF OF REPENTANCE

TEXT: 2 Cor. 7:8-11 *“For though I made you sorry with a letter, I do not repent, though I did repent: for I perceive that the same epistle hath made you sorry, though it were but for a season. ⁹Now I rejoice, not that ye were made sorry, but that ye sorrowed to repentance: for ye were made sorry after a godly manner, that ye might receive damage by us in nothing. ¹⁰For godly sorrow worketh repentance to salvation not to be repented of: but the sorrow of the world worketh death. ¹¹For behold this selfsame thing, that ye sorrowed after a godly sort, what carefulness it wrought in you, yea, what clearing of yourselves, yea, what indignation, yea, what fear, yea, what vehement desire, yea, what zeal, yea, what revenge! In all things ye have approved yourselves to be clear in this matter.”*

INTRO: The Apostle Paul is writing his second letter to the Corinthian Church here. This man has some very obvious feelings of love and concern for this Church. (He cares about what they think!) **2 Cor. 7:8-9** *“For though I made you sorry with a letter, I do not repent, though I did repent: for I perceive that the same epistle hath made you sorry, though it were but for a season. ⁹Now I rejoice, not that ye were made sorry, but that ye sorrowed to repentance: for ye were made sorry after a godly manner, that ye might receive damage by us in nothing.”*

The reason Paul has a special place in his heart for this particular Church is that on his second missionary journey, which was somewhere around A.D. 50, he became the first man ever to share the good news of the Gospel in the city of Corinth!

The City of Corinth was a very wealthy commercial center. Because of it's commerce, and geographical location it became a hub of activity not only for those who lived there but also for those in surrounding areas.

The moral climate of the city of Corinth was such, that by the most conservative of estimates, it was a City of great wickedness. The wickedness of the City caused it to be very fertile soil for the seed of the Gospel! **Romans 5:20** *“... Where sin abounded, grace did much more abound:”*

Out of that missionary journey came the Corinthian Church!

Paul not only spent a lot of time in this City declaring the good news of Jesus Christ, but he expended much effort giving written instructions to these people on how to order their personal lives, as well as their religious activities!

Paul begins verse eight of our text by saying, *“for though I made you sorry with a letter...”*

Paul refers to this letter in **2 Cor. 2:4** *“For out of much affliction and anguish of heart I wrote unto you with many tears; not that ye should be grieved, but that ye might know the love which I have more abundantly unto you.”*

There are two schools of thought with regard to this seemingly mysterious “letter”.

One School of thought is that there was a very severe “letter” from Paul to the Corinthian Church that was somehow lost and never recorded.

The second school of thought is that he is referring to the book of First Corinthians. After much study I am inclined to agree with this second scenario.

The reason I am inclined to agree with the latter of these two opinions is because of what Paul said in his first letter to the Corinthian Christians! (Paul makes my preaching sound easy!)

- 1) He addresses the divisions in the Church!
- 2) He addresses the source of the divisions!
- 3) He addresses the absence of discipline in the Church!
- 4) He addresses civil litigation between members of the body of Christ!
- 5) He addresses the moral decline of members of the Church!
- 6) He addresses marriage and divorce!
- 7) He addresses the eating of food sacrificed to idols! etc...

Now if you are a guilty party, this kind of preaching will make you do one of two things, get mad, or “**REPENT**”!!! (If you throw a rock into a pack of dogs the only one who barks is the one who got hit!)

This brings us to our subject matter for this message, “**REPENTANCE**”!

The doctrine of **“REPENTANCE”** is a very important doctrine in your Bible. 110 times the word **“REPENTANCE”** or some form of the word is used in Holy Writ!

Notice this, in Four verses the Apostle Paul uses the word **“REPENT”** twice, the word **“REPENTED”** once, the word **“REPENTANCE”** twice, the word **“SORRY”** Four times, the word **“SORROW”** twice, and the word **“SORROWED”** twice! Now what message do you think the Apostle was trying to drive across here?

I want us to look at the word **“REPENTANCE”**, in hopes that we can gain a proper understanding of it's meaning in our day to day lives.

“REPENTANCE”! As it is used here, comes from the Greek word **“METANOIA”** (met-an-oy-ah), meaning compunction for guilt including reformation!

The word **“COMPUNCTION”** means anxiety arising from the awareness of guilt. To **“REFORM”** means to amend or improve by change of form, or removal of faults or abuses!

So I think we could safely say that **“REPENTANCE”** means that we see where we have been wrong, acknowledge it, and set out with renewed passion never to repeat it!

This world has no problem with the words **“I’M SORRY”** but I wonder how much real **“REPENTANCE”** there is in this world, or better yet in the Church?

Paul said, Godly sorrow brings about **“REPENTANCE”**!

“REPENTANCE” is not a popular topic, but I can assure you that it is an important one!

You can’t get saved without **“REPENTING”**! You certainly can’t live for God long term without **“REPENTING”**!

“REPENTANCE” has become a lost sermon of the Church of this modern hour, but it was on the top of Paul’s list of candy sticks to preach!

There is much debate on the topic of what true **“REPENTANCE”** is.

Some believe you MUST shed tears! I've seen people shed enough tears to generate enough electricity for this town for several days, but they still don't live right!

Some people believe you must shake a preachers hand, or join the Church! I've seen people do both, but it did not change their lives!

So what is **“THE PROOF OF REPENTANCE”**?

Paul say's in verse Eleven there are Seven attributes that will assimilate themselves in the lives of those who learn the art of **“REPENTING”**, and I want us to look very closely at them because I believe they **“PROVE REPENTANCE”**;

I. WHAT CAREFULNESS!

A. 2 Cor. 7:11 *“For behold this selfsame thing, that ye sorrowed after a godly sort, what carefulness it wrought in you,...”*

The word **“CAREFULNESS”**, as it is used here, comes from the Greek word **“SPOUDE”** (spoo-day), meaning eagerness or earnestness!

Think about it. When you've been wrong, or sinned, that sin has been discovered, you have owned up to it, and you have made the proper apologies because you are truly sorry! Does it not make you far more **“CAREFUL”** or cautious when you approach the tempting point of that particular failure or sin the next time?

A portion of the **“PROOF OF REPENTANCE”** is that we will be **“CAREFUL”** to make things right with God, ourselves, and others!

Paul knew what it meant to sin against the Lord! **1 Tim. 1:15** *“This is a faithful saying, and worthy of all acceptation, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners; of whom I am chief.”*

Paul knew that he had spent a great deal of his life disappointing the Lord with his lifestyle. However, when he was convicted by the Holy Spirit, he **“REPENTED”**, and became extremely **“CAREFUL”** never to repeat his past failures!

B. This world's system say's, if you've done something wrong and were unfortunate to get caught, just say you are sorry, pay the minimum penalty, and move on! It's no big deal!

I have found that the sorrow of the world is for having been caught, not for what they have done!

Our justice system is a prime example of this short sighted philosophy. Violent criminals are being allowed early release not because they have been rehabilitated, but because of good behavior!

I want to tell you that anyone can be on good behavior for short periods of time. However, real “**REPENTANCE**” will make you “**CAREFUL**” or “**EAGER**” to do what ever is necessary to make sure you never repeat that same mistake again!

“CAREFULNESS” is “PROOF OF REPENTANCE”!

C. Notice what happened when King David’s Sin with Bathsheba was exposed by the prophet Nathan! **2 Samuel 12:13** *“And David said unto Nathan, I have sinned against the Lord...”*

Now I must tell you that even at this point David’s attitude is very different from the general Church population. No one had to drag the truth out of him, he just owned up to his own failure! (This would be a different world if everyone were as forthcoming as David was!)

David’s prayer of “**REPENTANCE**” before GOD is recorded in **Psalms 51:1-19** *“Have mercy upon me, O God, according to thy lovingkindness: according unto the multitude of thy tender mercies blot out my transgressions. ²Wash me thoroughly from mine iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin. ³For I acknowledge my transgressions: and my sin is ever before me. ⁴Against thee, thee only, have I sinned, and done this evil in thy sight: that thou mightest be justified when thou speakest, and be clear when thou judgest. ⁵Behold, I was shapen in iniquity; and in sin did my mother conceive me. ⁶Behold, thou desirest truth in the inward parts: and in the hidden part thou shalt make me to know wisdom. ⁷Purge me with hyssop, and I shall be clean: wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow. ⁸Make me to hear joy and gladness; that the bones which thou hast broken may rejoice. ⁹Hide thy face from my sins, and blot out all mine iniquities. ¹⁰Create in me a clean heart, O God; and renew a right spirit within me. ¹¹Cast me not away from thy presence; and take not thy holy spirit”*

from me. ¹²Restore unto me the joy of thy salvation; and uphold me with thy free spirit. ¹³Then will I teach transgressors thy ways; and sinners shall be converted unto thee. ¹⁴Deliver me from bloodguiltiness, O God, thou God of my salvation: and my tongue shall sing aloud of thy righteousness. ¹⁵O Lord, open thou my lips; and my mouth shall shew forth thy praise. ¹⁶For thou desirest not sacrifice; else would I give it: thou delightest not in burnt offering. ¹⁷The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit: a broken and a contrite heart, O God, thou wilt not despise. ¹⁸Do good in thy good pleasure unto Zion: build thou the walls of Jerusalem. ¹⁹Then shalt thou be pleased with the sacrifices of righteousness, with burnt offering and whole burnt offering: then shall they offer bullocks upon thine altar.”

David truly **“REPENTED”**! His **“REPENTANCE”** is evidenced by the fact that he was **“CAREFUL”** to never repeat this mistake again!

What better **“PROOF”** could a person offer that they have truly **“REPENTED”**, than to be **“CAREFUL”** to stay as far away from sin as they possibly can?

The reason that GOD was able to identify this man David as having a heart like himself is that not one time do you ever see David making this mistake again!

Do I think he was ever tempted again? Yes! Do I think the opportunity was presented for him to fall into this kind of sin again? Yes!

Why did he not fall into this sin repeatedly? Because he **“REPENTED”**, and his **“REPENTANCE”** brought about extreme caution, and **“CAREFULNESS”**!!! He was determined to **“PROVE HIS REPENTANCE”**!

The most wonderful words of this horrible dilemma can be found in 2 Samuel 12:13, *“... And Nathan said unto David, The Lord also hath put away thy sin; thou shalt not die.”*

Were there consequences to pay with regard to David’s sin? Yes, the child born to this unholy union died!

The real story here is that King David **REPENTED**, was forgiven, and became very **“CAREFUL”** never to repeat his failure again, thus GOD

was able to use him mightily!

If you will **“REPENT”** of your sin’s today, God will forgive you as well!

Once you have **“REPENTED”**, be **“CAREFUL”** not to make the same mistakes repeatedly!

II. WHAT CLEARING OF YOURSELVES!

A. 2 Cor. 7:11 *“For behold this selfsame thing, that ye sorrowed after a godly sort, what carefulness it wrought in you, yea, what clearing of yourselves...”*

The word **“CLEARING”** comes from the Greek word **“APOLOGIA”** (ap-ol-og-ee’-a), which means to answer for yourself with a plea, so as to completely confess!

In other words, to enter a plea of guilt so comprehensive that there would be nothing for the judge or jury to discover at a later date!
(Jason Cornett)

Paul is saying here that when you truly **“REPENT”**, Your **“REPENTANCE”** will be **“PROVEN”** by the fact that you are willing to completely **“CLEAR YOURSELF”** before GOD!

This world’s system say’s hide everything you can! Don’t admit to anything that has not been proven against you! Certainly don’t volunteer any incriminating information!

The goal seems to be to see if you can manipulate the system to the point of **“CLEARING YOURSELF”**!

I want to tell you today that no matter how many **“NOT GUILTY”** verdicts are rendered by this worlds system, they will never clear the conscience!

This popular modern day philosophy presents itself in every sector of our society.

Sure this philosophy is driving our society, but it has also found it’s way into the Church! (The all important question seems to be, how can we save face!)

This is a very damaging, damning philosophy because it leaves no room

for a person to “**CLEAR**”, or come clean with themselves, with their families, their government, or with GOD!

(A couple years ago the IRS gave amnesty for anyone who wanted to amend their returns, or file returns for certain years! MILLIONS RESPONDED!)

B. Paul is telling us here that the soul of man cries out for a gift of amnesty and oblivion!

We all have a need to “**CLEAR OURSELVES**” before GOD!

If anyone ever had a need to “**CLEAR THEMSELVES**” before GOD, Paul by his own admission did! **1 Tim. 1:15** *“This is a faithful saying, and worthy of all acceptance, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners; of whom I am chief.”*

You see, before Paul was saved his name was Saul, and he was attempting to build a career on persecuting the Church!

He was present at the stoning of Stephen. In fact, he held the coats for the executioners while they murdered Stephen. **Acts 7:58** *“... and the witnesses laid down their clothes at a young man's feet, whose name was Saul.”*

By his own admission, Saul was a poor excuse for a human being, but something revolutionary happened on the road to Damascus! **Acts 9:3-8** *“And as he journeyed, he came near Damascus: and suddenly there shined round about him a light from heaven: And he fell to the earth, and heard a voice saying unto him, Saul, Saul, why persecutest thou me? And he said, Who art thou, Lord? And the Lord said, I am Jesus whom thou persecutest: it is hard for thee to kick against the pricks. And he trembling and astonished said, Lord, what wilt thou have me to do? And the Lord said unto him, Arise, and go into the city, and it shall be told thee what thou must do. And the men which journeyed with him stood speechless, hearing a voice, but seeing no man. And Saul arose from the earth; and when his eyes were opened, he saw no man: but they led him by the hand, and brought him into Damascus.”*

Between this event on the road to Damascus, and a three day stay on

Straight Street in the home of Judas and his family, something lifechanging happened to Saul! (You would be surprised what a little living on Straight Street can do for you!)

I believe he **“CLEARED HIMSELF”**! Can you imagine the confession service that must have taken place on Straight Street? (Plane ride from Texarkana to Detroit! I confessed things I had never thought of doing!))

I don't think Saul was ashamed for anyone to hear his confession! He was sick to death of who he had become! Are you sick of who you are, where you are, and what you've become? **“REPENT”, “CLEAR YOURSELF”**!

Confession can be tough on the reputation, but it is good for the soul! **“CLEARING YOURSELF”** is **“PROOF OF REPENTANCE”**!

C. There are a lot of people who say they have **“REPENTED”**, but I wonder if they have entered a guilty plea that was so comprehensive that no matter how closely you looked, there would be nothing to find that was not under the blood?

What can wash away my sin? Nothing but the blood of JESUS!...etc.

I wonder if we have really **“CLEARED OURSELVES”**?

Paul did! Notice **Acts 9:11** *“And the Lord said unto him, **Arise, and go into the street which is called Straight, and enquire in the house of Judas for one called Saul, of Tarsus: for, behold, he prayeth,”***

GOD said to Ananias **Acts 9:15** *“But the Lord said unto him, **Go thy way: for he is a chosen vessel unto me, to bear my name before the Gentiles, and kings, and the children of Israel:”***

What a miracle!!! From public enemy number one to an Apostle in three short days!!! How? Paul said **“YEA WHAT CLEARING OF YOURSELVES”**!

Have you ever carried a huge load of guilt so far that you thought you couldn't go on? You wished there was someone you could tell? I have good news, you can tell it to Jesus, and he will help you **“CLEAR**

YOURSELF” thus proving your “REPENTANCE”!!!

III. WHAT INDIGNATION!

A. 2 Cor. 7:11 *“For behold this selfsame thing, that ye sorrowed after a godly sort, what carefulness it wrought in you, yea, what clearing of yourselves, yea, what indignation..”*

The word **“INDIGNATION”** as it is used here comes from the Greek word **“AGANAKTESIS”** (Ag-an-ak’tay-sis), which comes from the Greek word **“AGANAKTEOS”** (Ag-an-ak-teh-o), which means to be greatly afflicted, to be sorely displeased!

I want us to refer you once again to the definition of the word **“REPENTANCE”!**

“REPENTANCE” comes from the Greek word **“METANOIA”** (met-an-oy-ah), meaning compunction for guilt including reformation!

The word **“COMPUNCTION”** means anxiety arising from the awareness of guilt. To **“REFORM”** means to amend or improve by change of form, or removal of faults or abuses!

Think about it. When you’ve been wrong, or sinned, that sin has been discovered, you have owned up to it, and you have made things right with God, others, and yourself, proving that you are truly sorry! Does it not make you **“INDIGNANT”** or angry enough that you want to make sure that you never repeat that mistake again?

This world’s philosophy say’s, don’t let it upset you or get to you, ignore it, put it behind you, and go on with life! It’s no big deal!

The sad thing about all of this is that the Church has bought into this kind of thinking!

I have come here today to let you know that sin is still a big deal in the sight of GOD! Sin was a thing so serious that God sent his only begotten Son to die that it could be eradicated from the lives of those who would accept the blood sacrifice of Jesus as more than enough to cover their sin!

If GOD is that serious about sin, when it presents itself in our lives we should show a little **“INDIGNATION”** toward it!

B. The Apostle Paul is trying to tell us here that if you have truly “**REPENTED**”, you will “**PROVE**” it by showing enough “**INDIGNATION**” toward it, to burn the bridges of failure behind you!

Simon Peter knew what “**INDIGNATION**” toward sin was all about! In the Twenty Sixth chapter of Matthew Jesus tells his disciples that they will deny him!

Knowing human nature as I know it, I am sure Jesus’ words stirred a little “**INDIGNATION**” within the Disciples! They probably thought of all the hardships they had endured with and for Jesus, and now he is saying that they will deny him!!!

Notice what Peter say’s to Jesus, [Matthew 26:33](#)

“...Though all men shall be offended because of thee, yet will I never be offended.” He is saying, the rest of these clowns may do what you have predicted, but you can count on me! I would never do a thing like that! (He is about to cause a little church trouble!)

Notice Jesus’ response to Peter’s words, *“... Verily I say unto thee, That this night, before the cock crow, thou shalt deny me thrice.”*

I am assuming Peter became a little “**INDIGNANT**” here, based on his response! [Matthew 26:35](#)

“Peter said unto him, Though I should die with thee, yet will I not deny thee. Likewise also said all the disciples.”

However, we know that Peter reacted just as Jesus had predicted!

[Matthew 26:69-75](#) *“Now Peter sat without in the palace: and a damsel came unto him, saying, Thou also wast with Jesus of Galilee. ⁷⁰But he denied before them all, saying, I know not what thou sayest. ⁷¹And when he was gone out into the porch, another maid saw him, and said unto them that were there, This fellow was also with Jesus of Nazareth. ⁷²And again he denied with an oath, I do not know the man. ⁷³And after a while came unto him they that stood by, and said to Peter, Surely thou also art one of them; for thy speech bewrayeth thee. ⁷⁴Then began he to curse and to swear, saying, I know not the man.”* Just as Jesus had predicted, Peter denied knowing Jesus three times before sun-up!

Notice the words that follow! “... *And immediately the cock crew.* ⁷⁵*And Peter remembered the word of Jesus, which said unto him, Before the cock crow, thou shalt deny me thrice.*” The sound of that rooster crowing must have been the most horrible sound Peter had ever heard!

As the sound of that rooster crowing reverberated through his mind, it began to stir him to **“REPENT”**, and also caused feelings of **“INDIGNATION”** toward his failure!

The Bible says Peter’s response to his own sin was that “... *he went out, and wept bitterly.*”

C. Please understand that when Peter’s sin was exposed, you do not hear a word about anyone else’s failure but his!

Have you ever been totally disgusted with yourself because of sins and failures in your life? (The person who has given me the most problems in life is in this room this morning, and I am about to reveal who that person is! It is me!)

We need to come back to the place where we realize that it’s not my brother or my sister, but it’s me O Lord, standing in the need of prayer!

How long has it been since you were angry because of your own failures?

When Holy **“INDIGNATION”** because of our failures and sins becomes so pronounced that we are determined never to make that mistake again, **“THE PROOF OF REPENTANCE”** is beginning to manifest itself in our lives!

IV. WHAT FEAR!

A. The word **“FEAR”** as it is used here, comes from the Greek word **“PHOBOS”** (Fob’-os), which is derived from the word **“PHEBOMAI”** (Feb-om-i) which means alarm or fright, or to be terrified!

In other words Paul is saying here that when your sin has been exposed, and you have truly **“REPENTED”** the **“PROOF OF THAT REPENTANCE”** will be **“TERROR”** with regard to that failure!

This goes farther than just a healthy respect!

Please understand that I know that we are not to be living in “**FEAR**”! **2 Tim. 1:7** “*For God hath not given us the spirit of fear; but of power, and of love, and of a sound mind.*”

However, the fact that we realize we are human beings who experience moments of weakness, should strike a cord of “**FEAR**” in our hearts with regard to our ability to fail!

When you are “**AFRAID**” of something, you stay away from it! I am “**AFRAID**” of snakes! I would never go to a Church that handles snakes! I am so “**AFRAID**” of snakes that I kill ALL snakes!

I am “**AFRAID**” of heights! I will not climb to the top of a skyscraper to look off! I stay as far from the edge as I possibly can!!! Why? Because heights “**TERRIFY**” me!

B. Something that I found very interesting in doing the research for this message is that the word “**FEAR**” as it is used here, is not found in the Old Testament, but is actually used 32 times in the New Testament!

Could it be that under the law there was not a great need to speak of the “**TERROR**” of the Lord because they witnessed it on a regular basis?

However, under Grace, there is a need to remind the saints to “**FEAR**” failure!!!

Paul say’s to the Philippian Christians, **Philip. 2:12-15** “*Wherefore, my beloved, as ye have always obeyed, not as in my presence only, but now much more in my absence, work out your own salvation with fear and trembling. ¹³For it is God which worketh in you both to will and to do of his good pleasure. ¹⁴Do all things without murmurings and disputings: ¹⁵That ye may be blameless and harmless, the sons of God, without rebuke, in the midst of a crooked and perverse nation, among whom ye shine as lights in the world;”*

The first thing we must do is to “**WORK OUT OUR OWN SALVATION WITH FEAR AND TREMBLING**”!!!

Notice with me the words of **2 Cor. 7:1** “*Having therefore these promises, dearly beloved, let us cleanse ourselves from all filthiness of the*

flesh and spirit, perfecting holiness in the fear of God.”

Peter writes in **1 Peter 1:14-19** “*As obedient children, not fashioning yourselves according to the former lusts in your ignorance: ¹⁵But as he which hath called you is holy, so be ye holy in all manner of conversation; ¹⁶Because it is written, Be ye holy; for I am holy. ¹⁷And if ye call on the Father, who without respect of persons judgeth according to every man's work, pass the time of your sojourning here in fear: ¹⁸Forasmuch as ye know that ye were not redeemed with corruptible things, as silver and gold, from your vain conversation received by tradition from your fathers; ¹⁹But with the precious blood of Christ, as of a lamb without blemish and without spot:*”

Paul say’s in our text “**...YEA, WHAT FEAR...**” He was “**TERRIFIED**” of going back to his old ways! I believe it was the “**FEAR**” of allowing the old man to surface that caused Paul to live as far from failure as he did!

We have established that the New Testament is very clear that we are to “**FEAR**” failing to such a degree that it would cause us to live as close to Christ as we can!

So why, when we have such conclusive scriptural evidence, and such powerful personal examples, do we see such gross failures in ourselves as well as others? Because of the lack of a proper understanding of “**THE PROOF OF REPENTANCE**”!

C. The people who fail, are those who know no “**FEAR**”! (Examples: Samson, Judas, Demas, etc...)

Paul realized there were danger zones along the way! **1 Cor. 9:24-27** “*Know ye not that they which run in a race run all, but one receiveth the prize? So run, that ye may obtain. ²⁵And every man that striveth for the mastery is temperate in all things. Now they do it to obtain a corruptible crown; but we an incorruptible. ²⁶I therefore so run, not as uncertainly; so fight I, not as one that beateth the air: ²⁷But I keep under my body, and bring it into subjection: lest that by any means, when I have preached to others, I myself should be a castaway.*”

When Satan has tripped you up a time or two and you have truly repented, you will be able to say with Paul, “**...YEA, WHAT FEAR...**”!!! It is at this point that your “**REPENTANCE**” will be “**PROVEN**” by the level of “**FEAR**” that you exhibit toward that failure!

We must come to the point that the question will not be, how close to the world can I live and still be a Christian, but what can I do to please Jesus, and keep from failing!

This is truly “**THE PROOF OF REPENTANCE**”!

V. WHAT VEHEMENT DESIRE!

A. 2 Cor. 7:11 *“For behold this selfsame thing, that ye sorrowed after a godly sort, what carefulness it wrought in you, yea, what clearing of yourselves, yea, what indignation, yea, what fear, yea, what vehement desire...”*

The word “**VEHEMENT**” as it is used here comes from the Greek word “**EPIPOTHESIS**” (ep-ee-poth'-ay-sis), meaning “**a longing for**”.

It also means “**yearning**”, or “**intense craving**”!

The word “**DESIRE**” comes from the same Greek word meaning exactly the same thing.

It is believed that the writer here uses the same word twice, for emphasis sake.

Think about it. Paul's sinful condition has been exposed through the conviction of the Holy Spirit! He has “**REPENTED**” of his sin, and say's that the “**PROOF OF THAT REPENTANCE**” will be evidenced by what he “**LONGS FOR**”!!!

Paul say's to the Colossian Christians, **Col. 3:1-3** *“If ye then be risen with Christ, seek those things which are above, where Christ sitteth on the right hand of God. ²Set your affection on things above, not on things on the earth. ³For ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God.”*

The word “**SET**” here has to do with reigning in the mind!

The word “**AFFECTION**” here has to do with our desires!

Can I tell you that we are living in a day where the motto “**IF IT FEELS GOOD, DO IT**” is alive and well?

Our nation is in a state of total moral failure because we refuse to do what Paul is suggesting here!

Where has this new moral code of ethics taken us?

- 1) It has led to voters who are willing to ignore gross moral and ethical failures, as long as the economy is good! (Some of whom are members of A/G Churches!)
- 2) It has led to a government that is morally and ethically deficient!
- 3) It has led to Network television programming that is unfit for mature audiences, let alone children! (All the while Christians set watching with no conviction!)
- 4) It has led to a society that will condemn smoking, want to legalize marijuana, and excuse drunk driving!
- 5) It has led to a society that will cry out for more social programs to help the poor, and at the same time legalize gambling!
- 6) It has led to a society that will imprison a Jim Baker, and set free murderers, rapists, and child molesters!
- 7) It has led to a society that will accept adultery, fornication, and homosexuality as acceptable lifestyles, and lash out at people with biblical values!
- 8) It has led to cut-throat business deals!
- 9) It has led to a mentality that say's, climb the corporate ladder at any cost!
- 10) It has led to a mentality that say's, it doesn't matter who you destroy as long as you are successful!

The sad thing is that the Church as a whole is not much better off than the world!

We are living in a time when you can hardly tell the difference between the Church and the world!!!

Paul is saying here that **“IF”** we have truly **“REPENTED”** we will reign

in our carnal mind and nature, and will force if necessary, our desires to change.

This Christian life is not a path to be chosen by the faint hearted! It takes **“VEHEMENT DESIRE”** to follow Jesus!

B. Look at what the word has to say about our **“DESIRES”**, and what we are to do with them!

Col. 3:5-10 *“Put to death, therefore, whatever belongs to your earthly nature: sexual immorality, impurity, lust, evil desires and greed, which is idolatry. ⁶Because of these, the wrath of God is coming. ⁷You used to walk in these ways, in the life you once lived. ⁸But now you must rid yourselves of all such things as these: anger, rage, malice, slander, and filthy language from your lips. ⁹Do not lie to each other, since you have taken off your old self with its practices ¹⁰and have put on the new self, which is being renewed in knowledge in the image of its Creator.”*

1 Peter 2:11 *“Dear friends, I urge you, as aliens and strangers in the world, to abstain from sinful desires, which war against your soul.”*

Jesus himself said, **Matthew 16:24** *“Then Jesus said to his disciples, “If anyone would come after me, he must deny himself and take up his cross and follow me.””*

There are three things here:

- 1) Self denial! Does that sound like if it feels good do it?
- 2) Cross bearing! The cross is an instrument of capital punishment!
- 3) Followship! Our theme song must be “Where he leads, I will follow”!

This is not an exercise recommended for the spiritually anemic, it takes **“VEHEMENT DESIRE”** to follow Jesus!

It takes a made up mind to follow Jesus!

SONG:

Now the Champion had stood 40 day’s on a hill, and said send me a man

to fight. Now the Israelites had a brave heart you see, but their feet were full of fright. Then a boy with a sling and a pocket full of rocks, that knew how to trust and pray, said if your gonna run Goliath you'd better run now, cause I've come here to stay!

The decree had been signed by the hand of the King, but Daniel still talked to the Lord.

As the hungry lions were pacing around the den, here comes supper one roared.

But if you'd been standing anywhere close you'd heard Daniel say, if you're talking about me you can forget it boys, cause I came here to stay.

Now the boy's wouldn't bow and the King got mad, and said turn the furnace up high. Tie 'em up and throw 'em in the Hebrew boy's are gonna fry. But a little while later while looking in the fire the King heard Shadrach say, pull up a chair boy's and warm your hands, we've come here to stay!

CHORUS

Run if you want to, run if you will, but I've come here to stay. When I fall down, I try to get up, cause I didn't start out to play. It's a battlefield brother, not a recreation room, It's a fight and not a game. So run if you want to, run if you will, but I came here to stay!

C. Paul here in our text is saying, that his **“REPENTANCE”** will be proven by his longings, yearnings, and cravings!

From the day on the road to Damascus, to the end of his earthly journey, it is a proven fact that Paul had a **“VEHEMENT DESIRE”** to follow Jesus and to do the will of GOD!

We assume that this radical change was easy street for him, but notice what he say's to the Roman Christians, **Romans 7:23-25** *“But I see another law at work in the members of my body, waging war against the law of my mind and making me a prisoner of the law of sin at work within my members. ²⁴What a wretched man I am! Who will rescue me from this body of death? ²⁵Thanks be to God--through Jesus Christ our Lord! So then, I myself in my mind am a slave to God's law, but in the sinful nature a slave to the law of sin.”*

“PROVING REPENTANCE” will be no easier for us than it was for Paul, but it is a do-able task!

Notice with me again, **Col. 3:2-3** “Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things. ³For you died, and your life is now hidden with Christ in God.”

Remember, the word **“SET”** here has to do with reigning in the mind!

The word **“AFFECTION”** here has to do with our desires!

Notice he did not say that GOD was going to **“SET”** your **“AFFECTION”**! He said that we were to **“SET”** our own **“AFFECTION”** on things above!

GOD wants to bring us to the place in our walk with him that we are more inclined to;

- ... Edify, than gossip!
- ... Smile, than frown!
- ... Bend, than break!
- ... Go to church, than stay home!
- ... Pray than fellowship!
- ... Read our Bible, than read the newspaper!
- ... Work for GOD, than to work for ourselves!
- ... Pay our tithes, than to pay the bills!
- ... Submit to authority, than have our way!
- ... Stay married, than to divorce!
- ... Overcome sin, than to fall into sin!

Was this thing of **“PROVING REPENTANCE”** through **“VEHEMENT DESIRE”** always easy for Paul? No! And it will not be easy for you or me!

Then how is it possible to always have **“VEHEMENT DESIRE”** for the things of GOD?

Jesus himself said, **Luke 12:34** “*For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.*”

Your heart is the seat of your emotions! So what he is saying here is you will be passionate in the area that you have chosen for your heart to dwell!

The key to **“SETTING YOUR AFFECTIONS”**, and **“PROVING YOUR REPENTANCE”**, is getting your heart in the right place!!!

VI. WHAT ZEAL!

A. The word **“ZEAL”**, comes from the Greek word **“ZELOS”** (dzay'-los), and as it is used here means, **“ARDOR”**.

The word **“ARDOR”** means, (1) Emotional warmth; passion. (2) Enthusiasm. (3) Intense heat; fire.

The term **“ZEAL”**, here is different than the terms, **“VEMEMENT DESIRE”**. **“VEHEMENT DESIRE”** allows for us to get our focus back to where it should have been, and enables us to set our affections in the proper place, and on the proper things.

However the **“ZEAL”** spoken of here causes us to create a plan of action that will lead to the **“REVENGE”** that we will talk about later!!!

While Paul, who was then Saul, was on straight street he began to realize the awfulness of what he had been involved in. (Talk about the things he had done against the church.)

Sometime during this three day rendezvous with GOD, it began to dawn on Paul that if he was going to leave there a different kind of a person he had to form a plan of attack against the flesh, and against Satan!

Some people seem to believe that GOD fried Paul's brain with that search light from heaven, and he just woke up in another world!

Sure there were some things in Paul's life that GOD did change, but there were many more that Paul himself was going to have to change!

How is that possible? Through **“REPENTANCE”**! I want to refer you once again to the meaning of the word **“REPENTANCE”**.

“REPENTANCE” As it is used here, comes from the Greek word **“METANOIA”** (met-an-oy-ah), meaning compunction for guilt including reformation!

The word **“COMPUNCTION”** means anxiety arising from the awareness of guilt. To **“REFORM”** means to amend or improve by change of form, or removal of faults or abuses!

Please understand, GOD is not going to come down and hold a gun to

your head and make sure you change some things in your life. Some people say that when GOD wants me to quit this habit he will take away the desire...

When you truly **“REPENT”** you will find that you have enough **“ZEAL”** to choose a plan of action that will guarantee success!

“ZEAL” is the emotional motivation that drives the process of change!

The **“PROOF OF REPENTANCE”** is having adequate **“ZEAL”** to change!!!

B. We Pentecostals are really good at being stirred. (We cry, shout, laugh, dance, clap, jump, etc...)

I’m not interested in how many tears you can shed! Anybody can cry! If you don’t believe it come up here and let me see if I can unstop your tear ducts by hitting your thumb with a hammer!!!

I am not nearly as interested in how emotional you have become, what I want to know is that after the emotion has drained out of the service and sermon, are you still motivated enough to change?

I heard a preacher say one day that he did not have much confidence in **“DRY EYED CONVERSIONS”**!

Sure, I’ve been in Pentecostal circles long enough that I like to see puddles of tears on the altars too, but I can tell you that some people have ruined all the varnish on our altars, but they are still not changed!

So what is the answer? True **“REPENTANCE”** has always been the answer, and still is, because it produces enough **“ZEAL”** to develop a successful plan of attack!

C. Let me tell you what came out of that three day rendezvous with GOD on Straight Street.

First of all, true **“REPENTANCE”**! The reason I know Paul truly **“REPENTED”** is that after the emotion had all drained out of a face to face meeting with GOD, there was still enough **“ZEAL”** left that Paul formed a plan of attack to assure his success as a Child of GOD!

I believe Paul's "ZEAL" caused him to form a four part plan of attack, and here it is, as I see it;

1) DIE TO SIN AND SELF! Galatians 2:20 *"I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me; and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me, and gave himself for me."*

Paul "PROVED" this commitment throughout life!

Some believe that Paul wrote the book of Hebrews, and I too believe that he did, but whoever did certainly spoke out clearly on this subject.

Hebrews 12:1-2 *"Wherefore seeing we also are compassed about with so great a cloud of witnesses, let us lay aside every weight, and the sin which doth so easily beset us, and let us run with patience the race that is set before us, ²Looking unto Jesus the author and finisher of our faith; who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is set down at the right hand of the throne of God."*

2) LIVE AS CLOSE TO GOD AS POSSIBLE! Philip. 3:4-9

"Though I might also have confidence in the flesh. If any other man thinketh that he hath whereof he might trust in the flesh, I more:

⁵Circumcised the eighth day, of the stock of Israel, of the tribe of Benjamin, an Hebrew of the Hebrews; as touching the law, a Pharisee; ⁶Concerning zeal, persecuting the church; touching the righteousness which is in the law, blameless. ⁷But what things were gain to me, those I counted loss for Christ. ⁸Yea doubtless, and I count all things but loss for the excellency of the knowledge of Christ Jesus my Lord: for whom I have suffered the loss of all things, and do count them but dung, that I may win Christ, ⁹And be found in him, not having mine own righteousness, which is of the law, but that which is through the faith of Christ, the righteousness which is of God by faith:"

3) KNOW EVERYTHING THERE IS TO KNOW ABOUT GOD!

Philip. 3:10-16 *"That I may know him, and the power of his resurrection, and the fellowship of his sufferings, being made conformable unto his death; ¹¹If by any means I might attain unto the resurrection of the dead. ¹²Not as though I had already attained, either were already perfect: but I follow after, if that I may apprehend that for which also I am apprehended of Christ Jesus. ¹³Brethren, I count not myself to have apprehended: but*

this one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind, and reaching forth unto those things which are before, ¹⁴I press toward the mark for the prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus.

¹⁵*Let us therefore, as many as be perfect, be thus minded: and if in any thing ye be otherwise minded, God shall reveal even this unto you.*

¹⁶*Nevertheless, whereto we have already attained, let us walk by the same rule, let us mind the same thing."*

4) FINISH SUCCESSFULLY! 2 Tim. 4:6-8 *"For I am now ready to be offered, and the time of my departure is at hand. ⁷I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith: ⁸Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, shall give me at that day: and not to me only, but unto all them also that love his appearing."*

I used to have a Deacon that would aggravate me on the golf course by saying, "IT'S NOT HOW YOU DRIVE, IT'S HOW YOU ARRIVE"!

The thing that made Paul such a success with GOD is that he truly **"REPENTED"**, and the **"PROOF OF HIS REPENTANCE"** is the **"ZEAL"** that established a plan of attack against failure!

If you and I are going to be successful, we must do exactly the same thing!

VII. WHAT REVENGE!

A. The word **"REVENGE"** as it is used here, comes from the Greek word **"EKDIKESIS"** (ek-dik'-ay-sis) and means vindication, or retribution.

To vindicate means, **(1)** To clear from criticism, blame, or suspicion. **(2)** To defend against opposition. **(3)** To justify.

The word retribution means, punishment for evil done, or reward for good done!

Now I understand there is a great danger in what I am about to share with you today. Some people would like to take a sermon on **"REVENGE"**, and use it against someone in their family, a coworker, an employee, or an employer. The Word of God has something to say with regard to **"REVENGE"** against our fellow man:

Leviticus 19:18 *"Thou shalt not avenge, nor bear any grudge against the children of thy people, but thou shalt*

love thy neighbour as thyself: I am the Lord."

Matthew 5:39 *"But I say unto you, That ye resist not evil: but whosoever shall smite thee on thy right cheek, turn to him the other also."*

1 Peter 3:8-9 *"Finally, be ye all of one mind, having compassion one of another, love as brethren, be pitiful, be courteous: [¶]Not rendering evil for evil, or railing for railing: but contrariwise blessing; knowing that ye are thereunto called, that ye should inherit a blessing."*

Even though we are not to ever take **"REVENGE"** on another human being, we have been given permission by our Heavenly Father to take **"REVENGE"** on the enemy!

B. Following Paul's three day rendezvous with God on Straight Street he began immediately taking **"REVENGE"** on the enemy, and never let up until the final breath had been drawn!

Before conversion, Paul by his own admission was the chiefest of sinners! He was a very valuable tool in the hands of the enemy. When he was converted, he made up his mind to be at least as good a Christian as he was a sinner.

Let us take some time and look at the **"REVENGE"** Paul took against the enemy!

The Church at Antioch, inspired by the Holy Spirit ordained Paul and Barnabas for missionary service, and sent John Mark with them.

From this launching pad Paul was instrumental in preaching the Gospel all over the world, and establishing Churches in places that had never heard the Gospel of Christ before.

As you are well aware, Paul wrote most of the New Testament, thus, almost 2,000 years later he is still getting his **"REVENGE"** on the enemy, who had other plans for him!

C. The problem with many modern day Christians is that we have become so lethargic that we don't have enough spiritual adrenaline to cause us to go to Church three times a week, let alone take **"REVENGE"** on the enemy!

We have certainly been given the weapons necessary, to do damage against the kingdom of darkness! **Ephes. 6:10-18** “Finally, my brethren, be strong in the Lord, and in the power of his might. ¹¹Put on the whole armour of God, that ye may be able to stand against the wiles of the devil. ¹²For we wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world, against spiritual wickedness in high places. ¹³Wherefore take unto you the whole armour of God, that ye may be able to withstand in the evil day, and having done all, to stand. ¹⁴Stand therefore, having your loins girt about with truth, and having on the breastplate of righteousness; ¹⁵And your feet shod with the preparation of the gospel of peace; ¹⁶Above all, taking the shield of faith, wherewith ye shall be able to quench all the fiery darts of the wicked. ¹⁷And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God: ¹⁸Praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, and watching thereunto with all perseverance and supplication for all saints;”

2 Cor. 10:3-6 “For though we walk in the flesh, we do not war after the flesh: ⁴(For the weapons of our warfare are not carnal, but mighty through God to the pulling down of strong holds;) ⁵Casting down imaginations, and every high thing that exalteth itself against the knowledge of God, and bringing into captivity every thought to the obedience of Christ; ⁶And having in a readiness to revenge all disobedience, when your obedience is fulfilled.”

Some people are afraid to attempt to carry out a plan of “**REVENGE**” against the enemy, because they believe he is stronger than they are!!!

All power has been given to Christ! **Matthew 28:18** “And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.”

If you are a blood bought child of God, you are stronger and more powerful, than the devil!!!

Luke 10:19 “Behold, I give unto you power to tread on serpents and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy: and nothing shall by any means hurt

you.”

1 Cor. 10:13 “There hath no temptation taken you but such as is common to man: but God is faithful, who will not suffer you to be tempted above that ye are able; but will with the temptation also make a way to escape, that ye may be able to bear it.”

James 4:7 “Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you.”

Romans 16:20 “And the God of peace shall bruise Satan under your feet shortly. The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you. Amen.”

GO AHEAD! Step out there and take sweet “REVENGE” on the enemy until you can say with Paul, “**YEA WHAT REVENGE**”!

SONG: I went to the enemies camp and I took back what he stole from me, took back what he stole from me, took back what he stole from me. I went to the enemies camp and I took back what he stole from me. He’s under my feet, he’s under my feet, he’s under my feet, he’s under my feet, Satan is under my feet!”

VIII. IN ALL THINGS YOU HAVE APPROVED YOURSELVES TO BE CLEAR IN THIS MATTER!

A. Now we come to the conclusion of the entire matter. We have thoroughly addressed all Seven “**PROOFS OF REPENTANCE**”, and the Apostle then say’s, **2 Cor. 7:11** “... *In all things ye have approved yourselves to be clear in this matter.*”

First of all I would like to look at two very important words in verse Eleven. **(1)** Approved **(2)** Clear

(1) The word “**APPROVED**” comes from the Greek word, “**SUNISTAO**” (soon-is-tah’-o) and figuratively means to exhibit.

(2) The word “**CLEAR**” comes from the Greek word “**HAGNOS**” (hag-nos’) and means to be clean, perfect, or pure. In a figurative sense it means innocent.

In other words Paul is saying that through the Seven **“PROOF’S OF REPENTANCE”** you have exhibited that you are innocent in this matter!

B. Innocent of what?

You will recall that we began this series of sermons by talking about the letter Paul had written to this Church that might have initially stirred up some emotions of anger, but eventually led to Godly sorrow which produced **“PROOF OF REPENTANCE”**!

In order that we might understand what the Corinthian Church is being deemed **“INNOCENT”** of, we must first look at what Paul had charged them with;

- 1) Divisions in the Church! (Church located on Division street!)
- 2) The absence of discipline in the Church!
- 3) Civil litigation between members of the body of Christ!
- 4) The moral decline of members of the Church!
- 5) Willingness to treat marriage as something less than a covenant!
- 6) The eating of food sacrificed to idols!

Paul laid out some pretty stiff and serious charges against the Corinthian Church!

I wonder what the charges would be against some of us?

C. Paul used Fifteen chapters, 447 verses to lay out the charges, and then he say’s “IN ALL THINGS YOU HAVE EXHIBITED THAT YOU ARE INNOCENT IN THIS MATTER”!!!

Think of it, all the trouble to bring the charges for an **“INNOCENT”** verdict!!!

Is that not a little frustrating and disappointing?

How could a thing like that happen? These are serious charges!

Here is how it happened;

- (1) They were guilty as charged to begin with!
- (2) Paul’s charges against them caused them to sorrow to **“REPENTANCE”**!
- (3) Their **“REPENTANCE”** was proven by their attitude, action, and conduct!

(4) Because of their “**REPENTANCE**”, and “**THE PROOF OF THEIR REPENTANCE**” they were found “**INNOCENT**” of all charges!

Now this thing would be treated as if it never happened!

CONCLUSION: The same things happens with us! We have been formally charged by the Word of God! We are guilty! The charges have us dead to rights!

Jesus has paid the price for our pardon and redemption! **Isaiah 55:7**
“Let the wicked forsake his way, and the unrighteous man his thoughts: and let him return unto the Lord, and he will have mercy upon him; and to our God, for he will abundantly pardon.”

1 John 1:9 *“If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.”*

The only thing remaining is for us to plead guilty to all charges, sorrow to “**REPENTANCE**”, and “**PROVE OUR REPENTANCE**” through our lifestyles!

When this has been done, notice the results!

Psalms 130:4 *“But there is forgiveness with thee, that thou mayest be feared.”*

Psalms 103:1-3 *“Bless the Lord, O my soul: and all that is within me, bless his holy name. ²Bless the Lord, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits: ³Who forgiveth all thine iniquities; who healeth all thy diseases;”*

Ephesians 1:3-7 *“Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who hath blessed us with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ: ⁴According as he hath chosen us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and without blame before him in love: ⁵Having predestinated us unto the adoption of children by Jesus Christ to himself, according to the good pleasure of his will, ⁶To the praise of the glory of his grace, wherein he hath made us accepted in the beloved. ⁷In whom we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, according to the riches of his grace;”*

Psalm 103:12 *“As far as the east is from the west, so far hath he removed our transgressions from us.”*

When I was a child growing up in a Pentecostal Church a song was sang quite often that simply say's:

You ask me why I'm happy so I'll just tell you why, because my sins are gone; And when I meet the scoffers who ask me where they are, I say, my sins are gone.

‘Twas at the old time altar where God came in my heart and now, my sins are gone; The Lord took full possession, the devil did depart, I'm glad my sins are gone.

When satan comes to tempt me and tries to make me doubt, I say, my sins are gone; You got me into trouble, but Jesus got me out, I'm glad my sins are gone.

I'm living now for Jesus, I'm happy night and day, because my sins are gone; My soul is filled with music, with all my heart I say, I know my sins are gone.

CHORUS: They're underneath the Blood on the Cross of Calvary, as far removed as darkness is from dawn; In the sea of God's forgetfulness that's good enough for me. Praise God, my sin's are gone.

Someone said, “when God forgave me he cast my sins in the sea of his forgetfulness, and then put up a sign that say's **NO FISHING**”

“IN ALL THINGS YOU HAVE APPROVED YOURSELVES TO BE CLEAR IN THIS MATTER”!!!